

Traded Before They're Earned

An Interview Study of the Informal Minute-Economy Around a Household Screen-Time Ledger

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Motivation

Household screen-time apps present an “earned-minutes” balance as a closed ledger, credited by chores or reading and debited by use. Vendors treat the balance as authoritative. Little is known about what a family does once it reads zero mid-holiday.

Research questions

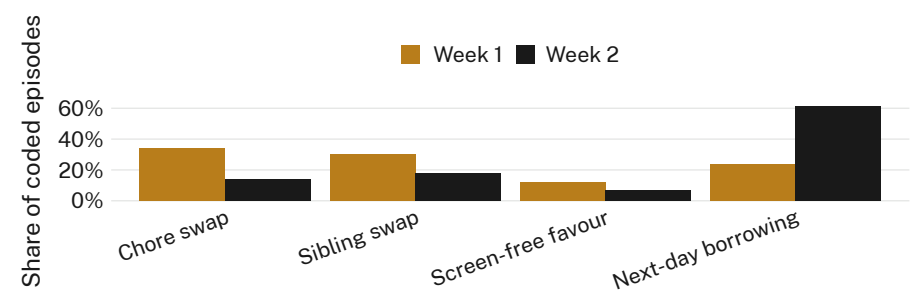
- What tactics do families invent once a ledger balance is spent?
- Does the tactic mix shift between the first and second week of the school holidays?
- How often do families use the app’s own sanctioned borrow-ahead feature?

Study design

- 34 households · 58 semi-structured parent-teen interviews · two-week school-holiday window
- Transcripts coded into a four-category trade taxonomy by two independent coders ($\kappa = 0.79$)
- Interview guide and coding scheme pre-registered; no category added post hoc

What we found

Sibling swaps and chore-for-minutes trades dominate the first week. By the second, next-day borrowing becomes the majority tactic, almost entirely bypassing the ledger’s own borrow-ahead function.



Next-day borrowing rose from 24% to 61% of coded negotiation episodes between week one and week two ($n = 212$ episodes, 34 households, 6–14 July 2026), while the app’s sanctioned borrow-ahead feature accounted for under 4% of trades in either week.

Implications

The ledger’s balance functions as a currency families quietly renegotiate around, not a limit they observe. Its one sanctioned borrowing mechanism goes almost entirely unused, replaced by peer-to-peer arrangements the ledger has no way to see. Next: a term-time replication, to test whether the informal economy survives once the holidays’ compressed timeframe lifts.

Selected references

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